1.3 The Stamp Act

In 1765, the easiest way to become unpopular with your neighbors was to be appointed by the king to collect his latest tax.

MAIN IDEA An attempt to impose a new type of tax sparked open protests and violent action, which forced the British government to repeal the tax.

A NEW KIND OF TAX

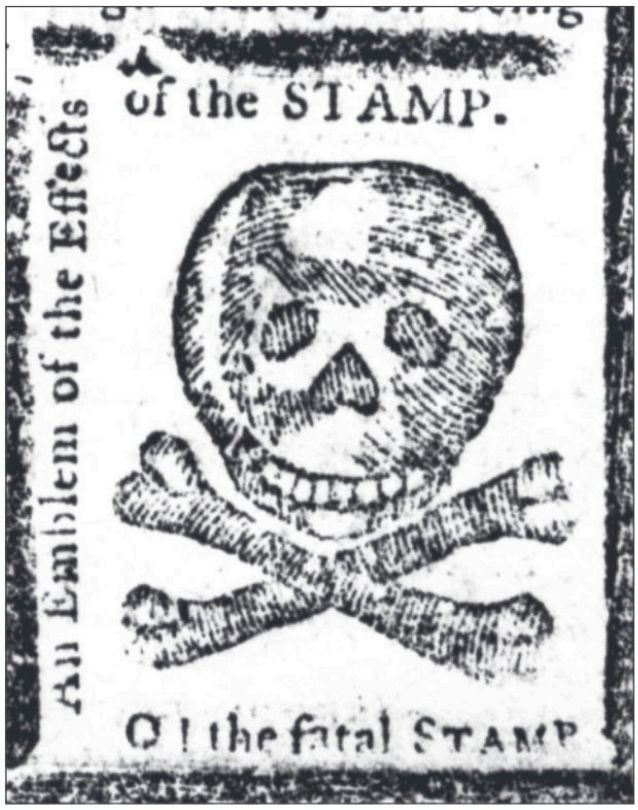
Passed by Parliament in 1765, the **Stamp Act** provoked an even greater storm of protest. Unlike previous laws, the Stamp Act did nothing to further Britain's mercantilist aims. Instead, it was designed purely to raise revenue to pay for the soldiers stationed in the colonies.

The Stamp Act required that all printed materials have a special government stamp. Items subject to the law included newspapers, playing cards, court documents, and sales receipts for land. So, for example, a person selling or buying a piece of land would also pay a British official to stamp the sales document. Colonists could only pay officials for the stamp with gold or silver coins—both of which were rare in the colonies. British courts enforced the Stamp Act by taking away any land or property involved in sales conducted without the stamps.

To the colonists, the Stamp Act was a shocking example of taxation without representation. Philadelphia merchant John Reynell said, "The point in dispute is a very important one, if the Americans are to be taxed by a Parliament where they are not nor can be Represented, they are no longer Englishmen but Slaves."

PROTESTING BRITISH GOODS

Colonial reactions to the Stamp Act were increasingly angry. **Patrick Henry** was a young politician and newly elected to Virginia's House of Burgesses. He persuaded the assembly to pass a series of resolutions that defended the colonists' right to tax themselves rather than to be taxed by Parliament. The resolutions declared that "the General Assembly of this colony . . . have the sole right . . . to lay taxes and impositions upon its inhabitants." When newspapers spread word of



Stamp Act Resistance
The hated Stamp Act was scheduled to take effect on November 1, 1765. Philadelphia newspaper printer William Bradford designed the October 31 "tombstone edition" of the *Pennsylvania Journal* with this skull and crossbones "stamp" to represent the death of the newspaper due to the Stamp Act. Bradford then ignored the act and continued publishing his paper.

Virginia's action, other colonies responded. Rhode Island instructed officials to ignore the stamp tax. Several other colonies passed resolutions similar to Virginia's resolution.

Colonists in cities such as Boston and Philadelphia soon realized they had more in common with each other than with Britain, and they began to organize. In Boston, a group rioted against the Stamp Act.

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Museum of Fine Arts, Boston

Paul Revere was a father, husband, silversmith, and member of the Sons of Liberty. He left his mark on America by crafting many treasures relating to the American Revolution. Some of Revere's finest work is housed in Boston's Museum of Fine Arts.

The Sons of Liberty Bowl featured the engraved names of 92 members of the Massachusetts House of Representatives. In 1767, they refused to retract a letter sent throughout the colonies protesting the Townshend Acts, which taxed paper, tea, glass, and other goods imported from Britain. This act of peaceful protest by the "Glorious Ninety-Two" was a major step leading to the American Revolution.

In the same year that Paul Revere crafted the Sons of Liberty Bowl, artist John Singleton Copley (KOP-lee) honored the silversmith by painting his portrait. Copley's decision to represent Revere as an artisan at work embodies the concept of Americans as builders and crafters throughout history.



Sons of Liberty Bowl Commissioned by the Sons of Liberty and made by Paul Revere, this silver bowl joins the Declaration of Independence and the Constitution as the nation's three most precious historical treasures.



Paul Revere In 1768, Copley painted Paul Revere engraving a teapot. It is his only finished portrait of an artisan at work.

They damaged the home of Andrew Oliver, the official in charge of stamping documents, and destroyed the governor's house. Oliver promptly resigned. Protestors in other colonies also acted to prevent the distribution of stamps. By the end of 1765, the stamp distributors in all the colonies except Georgia had resigned.

Some of the men who led the angry crowds called themselves the **Sons of Liberty**. They were mostly merchants, shopkeepers, and craftsmen. The Sons of Liberty also organized a **boycott**, a form of protest that involves refusing to purchase goods or services. Merchants in New York City, Boston, and Philadelphia agreed to stop importing goods from Britain.

In 1766, the protestors succeeded. Parliament **repealed**, or canceled, the Stamp Act. The colonists had taken their first major step toward independence from Britain and creating a new American identity.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How did the Stamp Act raise revenue for the British government?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why did the Stamp Act provoke such a strong response?
3. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** What events led up to the repeal of the Stamp Act?

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